

Fine-tuned Prints

MFDs—Multi-functional Devices—have progressed a lot since the days of being just copy and print machines...

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Let's look at some of the things they can do now. We start off with connectivity. Fax has been around for a while now and is still found on most MFDs, to eliminate the need for a PC and an Internet connection if documents have to be sent from one place to another. E-mail is the newcomer, and is best for those with an Internet connection; you can now directly send scanned documents to anyone via the Internet directly through the MFD.

The laser MFD doesn't even have to be connected to a PC any longer; you can keep it in one corner of your room and it'll connect wirelessly to a machine—and other machines can wirelessly connect to it—in addition to USB connectivity.

Memory card readers are another addition. You can insert memory cards from your digital camera or phone to transfer data onto the MFD for printing or other purposes.

Let's not miss out on the scanning and printing features. Laser MFDs, for example, are much cheaper to run than their inkjet counterparts, and the price itself for most MFDs is now low enough to be practical for home users. The performance of laser printers, too, far exceeds that of inkjet printers, which make them perfect for office use.

Optimum Scanning Settings

You notice while scanning is that as scanning dpi increases, so does the time. In most cases, you don't really need 300 dpi. 72 dpi to 100 dpi should

suffice for most Web-based applications or regular desktop use. Only when you're required to scan for other print media will you require the higher resolutions such as 300 dpi or more.

Quality drops the moment you save the image using a lossy compression format such as JPEG. If quality is what you need, lossless formats such as TGA or TIFF ought to be used. If you scanned at a high resolution, make sure it's stored with the same or a similar dpi.

For images to be processed using an OCR (Optical Character Recognition) software, try and keep dpi as high as possible in order to get more accurate conversion.

Optimum Printing Settings

Text documents can waste toner if high-quality prints are taken, especially in moderate-sized offices, where large numbers are printed. In such cases, you can make a few changes to your printer settings to optimise the use of toner cartridge.

You need to be on the machine to which the MFD is connected. In the Control Panel, click on Printers and Faxes. Right-click on the MFD's icon and click Properties. Click the Printing Preferences button. Depending on the printer, click on the tab for quality settings. Some of the settings that can help save a lot on toner costs are the printing dpi and the colours used. If text forms the major part of your printouts, you can switch to a complete black and white printing scheme to save on the colour cartridges. The brightness and contrast settings do help a lot as well. Some printers have an "economical" printing mode, which usually saves toner.

Interpolated Images

Some scanners might sport unimaginable scanning resolutions. These claims aren't always true—*interpolation* is probably what's being used. The resolution isn't the real optical resolution; it's software-enhanced. It's similar to digital

zoom in a digital camera. In interpolation, images' resolutions are increased with the same amount of data. This results in poor-quality images. Avoid using interpolated scanning resolutions as far as possible.

The major cost these days isn't the printing device itself, but the running costs. Cartridges are still quite costly, and this is where laser MFDs are the better option overall. A toner cartridge lasts a lot longer, and if you think you're going to print a lot of text, you can always stick to black toner cartridges for best economy.

Cleaning Your Laser MFD

Note: Opening and cleaning your laser printer toner can void your warranty and can be dangerous—proceed with caution!

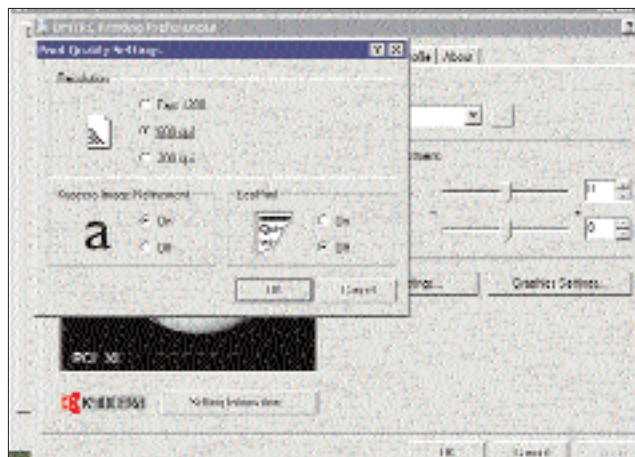
The component in your laser MFD that mainly requires cleaning is the laser printing device. You must take great care while cleaning the printer, as the laser printer toner powder is really



Keep your MFD nice and clean

fine and contains hazardous materials. The particles in air don't settle very quickly either. Use a mask to make sure you don't breathe in any.

Start by turning off the power and unplugging the printer. Next, open up the laser printer and remove any paper sheets from the trays. Wear a mask and gloves if needed, and remove the toner carefully. Use a brush (or a vacuum cleaner, carefully) to clean out any toner powder lying around. Use a cloth to clean out any toner stuck to the printer's insides. It's also best to dispose of the cloth once you're done cleaning. Make sure not to damage any components or cables. Using isopropyl alcohol on a cloth is a good way to clean stubborn stains. You can use this to clean the rollers as well. When you're done, put the toner cartridge back into the



Don't go overboard on the dpi settings if you don't need them